



The Sony Bravia Z450A

is the world's first LCD TV with Motionflow 200 Hz technology



Philips 52PFL9703/98

arguably one of the best looking displays in this comparison test and one of the best looking displays we've seen. The surface of the front bezel is a transparent fibre material and the bottom is piano black which gives it a very classy looking smooth finish that appears translucent. In fact at first glance we thought the fibre itself was black coloured. The stand is lovely looking and made of solid, half-inch thick glass, which adds a lot to the weight of the display. There is a small fibre bezel running right around the display and this makes it appear bulkier. The unit we received had a "made in Belgium" badge on the rear — a difference from most of the other displays, which were made either in Japan, Korea or India. Sadly upon powering on the display we noticed it had one dead pixel that was stuck on the colour green — although this is definitely a one-off glitch we were disap-

pointed mainly because of our very high expectations.

In the 16 shade-intensity and 256-colour ramp tests this display showed very good variations in colour and it was one of the two displays that provided such good results. Text quality was mediocre but the reverse text test was decent.

When watching movies there was a peculiar issue with dark areas of the screen which appeared reddish, and not black, or dark-grey as it should be. Other than this everything was fine and 1080p content looked crisp and clear, with good colours and contrast. Obviously the screen size makes for a very enjoyable home-theatre experience, the only sore point of course being the issue mentioned above. Priced at Rs 2,24,990 the Philips 52PFL9703/98 is not cheap, but as far as 52-inch LCDs go, it is not astronomically priced either. At the price there are alternatives available so we recommend you not getting bitten by this bug.

Sony KLV-52W400A: Dial W for wide

This display is catchy with a slim side and top bezel livered in smooth black fibre that is set with a multitude of tiny, shiny particles that give it a shiny satin-like look. The speakers are on the bottom and to the sides and these appear to curve inwards giving the display a slightly sleek, futuristic look. The speakers are finished in steel-grey. Above the speakers is a chrome strip that is a contrast to the steel-



Sony KLV-52W400A

How we tested



We did not divide these displays into any categories based on screen size since we were more interested in which of them made the most sense for their price. We hooked up these displays to a test PC using our standard HDMI connect. The PC configuration consisted of an AMD Athlon X2 6000+, 2 GB of RAM, an ASUS GeForce 8200 motherboard and an XFX 9800 GT graphics card. We used a hardware display calibrator, the Spyder 3 Elite (<http://spyder.datacolor.com/product-mc-s3elite.php>) to calibrate each display and measure colour and gamma levels. This colorimeter uses a seven-detector engine and an embedded ambient light sensor along with a large light aperture to calibrate accurately and is the choice of imaging professionals the world over. Throughout the test we ensured even external lighting to reduce variations in both calibration and testing results. Once each display was calibrated with the Spyder, we began our tests. A warm-up time of 30 minutes was given to each display prior to testing to minimise the effect of this variable.

In terms of features we noted down the connectivity options of these displays. Connects are of vital importance since any display could be used in a variety of situations and absence of a particular connect limits usage scenarios. Sometimes multiple connects of the same type are also required and we gave marks not only for presence of connects but also the quantity of connects. For example a display with four HDMI ports got double the rating than a display with two ports. We also rated the ergonomics of usage and button placement and the remote unit. The intuitiveness of the menu system was also graded as was the stability of the stand and its pivot functionality.

In terms of performance we used the Spyder 3 Elite to give us an accurate measure of the actual contrast ratio — the one that manufacturers do not want to tell you. It comes as no surprise when the difference in rated figures and actual specifications is as much as 500 per cent! We also used DisplayMate Video Edition which gave us the chance to study the colour reproduction and contrast output of the test candidates. Finally we ran every sort of movie on these displays ranging from Blu-Ray, to 1080p content to DVDs to judge colour and contrast practically. Finally we did a couple of text and presentation tests to check for text clarity and font rendition.

grey of the speaker grilles and the piano finished black of the screen bezel. In the middle of the bottom bezel, the word Sony is backlit in white. This may look garish to some; but we feel its not overdone, and we give Sony credit for knowing the fine line between classy and loud. This display was the only one that came with what Sony calls a DM Port or Digital Media Port. Basically this allows connecting of PMPs and such to the display unit. The device can charge through this port while music can be played through the display units speakers and artist information can be displayed on-screen. Obviously its something that will have its share of compatibility issues but it's a novel feature that warrants mention.

While calibrating this display the Spyder made things look very dark on-screen. In fact repeated attempts at calibrating met with the same fate and eventually we did a little manual brightening up.

The beauty of the Spyder 3 Elite and the display profile it creates is the fact that one can adjust brightness and contrast after RGB calibration has been done and this does not affect the colours at all. Obviously there is a limit within which manual tuning can be done without upsetting the colours, but it's a useful feature and a serious plus for the Spyder that came most handy with this display.

What was immediately noticeable was the quality of text, which was good with everything looking sharp. The blues on this display are a little deficient in comparison to the reds and the greens and Display Mate attested to this fact with slightly deficient blue gamut. In typical Sony style the reds are a little aggressive and post calibration we noted that the Spyder had turned down the reds significantly. However, it was impossible to negate the slight bias this display had to the colour red and this makes its presence felt with rendering bright red objects on-screen. These appear slightly over-rich and saturated. Although to be honest the issue with the other Sony display where the dark areas appeared reddish was not repeated here. Overall movie quality was good, with very decent contrast and an enjoyable experience. The price of this